QUESTION 1
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Geologist Adaora Ibe studied sedimentary rock layers in the Rift Valley of eastern Africa. Ibe found that a layer dated to approximately 70,000 years ago contained an unusually high concentration of volcanic ash mixed with fossilized freshwater diatoms -- microscopic algae that live only in lake environments. Ibe proposed that a massive volcanic eruption around that time deposited ash into a large lake that once occupied the valley floor, and the ash and diatoms were subsequently preserved together as the lake dried up.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Ibe's proposal?
A: Volcanic ash with the same chemical signature has been found in sedimentary layers across three other sites in eastern Africa, all dated to approximately 70,000 years ago.
B: Geochemical analysis of the surrounding terrain revealed ancient shoreline deposits consistent with a large freshwater lake that existed in the Rift Valley between 80,000 and 60,000 years ago, and the ash-bearing layer falls entirely within the boundaries of these shoreline deposits.
C: The species of freshwater diatoms found in the ash layer are known to thrive in alkaline water conditions, which are common in volcanic regions.
D: The Rift Valley has experienced multiple volcanic eruptions over the past 500,000 years, and ash deposits from different eruptions are found at various depths throughout the sedimentary record.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ibe's proposal requires TWO things to be true: (1) a lake existed at the right time, and (2) ash fell into it. B confirms BOTH: ancient shoreline evidence proves the lake, and the ash layer sits inside those boundaries. A only proves eruption happened (part of the story). Shortcut: when a hypothesis has multiple necessary conditions, the best support is the answer that confirms the most conditions simultaneously.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 2
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Education researcher Pablo Medina analyzed graduation rates across 80 high schools in a state that had implemented a mandatory tutoring program for underperforming students. Medina found that overall graduation rates increased by 6% statewide in the three years after the program began. Medina concluded that the mandatory tutoring program was responsible for the improvement in graduation rates.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Medina's conclusion?
A: The mandatory tutoring program cost significantly more per student than voluntary after-school programs that had been available previously.
B: Teachers at schools with the largest graduation rate increases reported strong support for the tutoring program and higher job satisfaction.
C: When the data was broken down by student group, graduation rates for students who participated in the mandatory tutoring actually declined by 2%, while graduation rates rose by 9% among students who were not required to participate, driven by a simultaneous change in the state's graduation requirements that made exams easier.
D: Three neighboring states that did not implement mandatory tutoring programs also saw increases in graduation rates during the same period, though by smaller margins.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is a Simpson's paradox question. The OVERALL number improved, but the specific group the program targeted actually got WORSE. The overall improvement was driven by other students benefiting from easier graduation requirements. D is tempting (other states improving too suggests a national trend), but C is more devastating because it shows the program's target population declined. Shortcut: when an overall statistic is cited, check whether the subgroup data tells the opposite story.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 3
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Archaeologist Yemi Adeyemi excavated a site in the Benin region of West Africa dated to approximately 1200 CE. Adeyemi uncovered a complex system of underground channels lined with fired clay. Some scholars have interpreted these channels as part of an irrigation system for agriculture. Adeyemi, however, argues that the channels served a metallurgical purpose -- specifically, as a ventilation and drainage system for underground smelting furnaces used to produce bronze.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Adeyemi's argument over the irrigation interpretation?
A: Chemical analysis of residue inside the channels revealed high concentrations of copper and tin oxides -- byproducts of bronze smelting -- and the clay lining showed evidence of exposure to temperatures exceeding 1,000 degrees C, far above what irrigation channels would experience.
B: The excavation site also contained fragments of bronze sculptures and casting molds consistent with the Benin bronze-making tradition known from later centuries.
C: No fossilized seeds, pollen, or other agricultural remains were found in the soil immediately surrounding the underground channels.
D: Similar underground channel systems have been found at other West African sites, where they have been conclusively identified as irrigation infrastructure.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: The question asks you to support smelting OVER irrigation. A provides DIRECT MATERIAL EVIDENCE from inside the channels: copper/tin residue (smelting byproduct) and extreme heat exposure. These are physically incompatible with irrigation. B shows bronze was made at the site but doesn't connect the channels to the process. C uses ABSENCE of evidence (no crops), which is weaker than PRESENCE of evidence (A). Shortcut: positive material evidence from the contested object itself beats negative evidence or evidence from nearby objects.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 4
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Psychologist Carmen Reyes conducted a study in which participants played a computer game that measured reaction times. Reyes found that participants who drank two cups of green tea thirty minutes before the game had reaction times that were 15% faster than those of participants who drank water. Reyes concluded that a compound in green tea directly enhances neural processing speed in the brain.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Reyes's conclusion?
A: The participants ranged in age from 18 to 65 and included both regular and non-regular tea drinkers.
B: Participants who drank green tea reported enjoying the beverage and feeling more alert, while the water group reported no change in mood.
C: The 15% improvement in reaction times was consistent across three separate testing sessions conducted on different days.
D: When a third group was given coffee containing the same amount of caffeine as the green tea but none of green tea's other compounds, this group showed an identical 15% improvement in reaction times.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Reyes says a GREEN TEA COMPOUND enhances processing. D shows that COFFEE with the same caffeine produced the same result. This means caffeine (found in many beverages) -- not a compound specific to green tea -- is the active ingredient. The conclusion attributes the effect to the wrong cause. B is tempting because 'feeling alert' could suggest expectation effects, but it doesn't directly test the mechanism. Shortcut: if another substance with a shared ingredient produces the same effect, the specific substance isn't the cause -- the shared ingredient is.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 5
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Literary scholar Tomasz Kowalczyk analyzed the novel structure of Polish author Maria Jankowska's 1952 work 'The Frozen River.' Kowalczyk noted that the novel's twelve chapters grow progressively shorter, with the first chapter spanning 40 pages and the final chapter consisting of only three sentences. Some critics have dismissed this as poor editorial planning, but Kowalczyk argues that the diminishing chapter lengths are a deliberate structural metaphor for the protagonist's gradual loss of voice under an authoritarian regime.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Kowalczyk's argument?
A: Jankowska's novel was banned by state censors shortly after its publication in 1952 due to its critical depiction of government authority.
B: Several other Eastern European novelists of the mid-twentieth century also employed unconventional chapter structures as a form of political commentary.
C: Each chapter's word count corresponds precisely to the percentage of dialogue spoken by the protagonist -- as the protagonist speaks less and less across the novel, the chapters shrink proportionally, while chapters dominated by government officials' speech are among the longest.
D: The first edition of the novel matches Jankowska's original manuscript exactly, with no editorial alterations to chapter lengths or divisions.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Kowalczyk claims the shrinking chapters = loss of voice. C shows the structure is internally linked to the protagonist's dialogue: less protagonist speech = shorter chapter, more government speech = longer chapter. This PATTERN WITHIN THE TEXT confirms the interpretation isn't coincidental. D confirms the structure was intentional (no editor changes), but intentional structure could serve any purpose -- D doesn't confirm it's about voice/authoritarianism. Shortcut: for structural-metaphor claims, look for internal textual patterns that match the proposed interpretation.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 6
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Economist Nkemdirim Okafor studied the impact of a universal basic income (UBI) pilot program in a small Canadian province. The province randomly selected 2,000 residents to receive monthly payments of $1,500 for three years, while a control group of 2,000 residents received no payments. Okafor found that UBI recipients were 30% more likely to start new businesses than control group members. However, critics argued that UBI recipients may have started businesses simply because they had more money to invest, not because the guaranteed income reduced the perceived risk of entrepreneurship, as Okafor claimed.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Okafor's risk-reduction explanation over the critics' investment-capital explanation?
A: Among UBI recipients who already had personal savings exceeding $50,000 before the pilot -- enough to fund a small business independently -- the rate of new business formation was still 28% higher than among control group members with equivalent savings, and surveys of these recipients cited 'reduced fear of failure' as their primary motivation.
B: Businesses started by UBI recipients had a three-year survival rate of 60%, compared to 45% for businesses started by non-recipients during the same period.
C: UBI recipients who started businesses reported using an average of 40% of their monthly UBI payments directly for business expenses during the startup phase.
D: Control group members who reported wanting to start a business but not doing so cited financial uncertainty as the primary barrier in 70% of cases.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Two competing explanations: (1) more money to invest, (2) reduced risk perception. A isolates the mechanism by looking at people who ALREADY HAD ENOUGH MONEY. If investment capital were the driver, wealthy UBI recipients wouldn't start businesses at higher rates than wealthy non-recipients -- but they did. Plus, they cited 'reduced fear of failure.' This eliminates the money explanation and supports the risk explanation. D is tempting because financial uncertainty sounds like risk, but it describes the CONTROL group, not the mechanism for UBI recipients.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 7
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Marine ecologist Henrik Larsen studied the decline of sea otter populations along a stretch of the Alaskan coastline. Larsen found that sea otter numbers had dropped by 60% over the past decade. After analyzing water quality, prey availability, and disease rates -- all of which appeared normal -- Larsen concluded that increased predation by orcas (killer whales) was the primary cause of the decline, noting that orcas had been observed in the area with increasing frequency.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Larsen's conclusion?
A: Populations of harbor seals and sea lions along the same coastline have also declined over the past decade, though by smaller margins than sea otters.
B: Stomach content analysis of orcas in the region showed that fish and squid composed over 80% of their diet, with marine mammals representing a small fraction.
C: Orcas have been documented preying on sea otters in Alaskan waters for at least fifty years, well before the current population decline began.
D: The water quality and prey availability samples in Larsen's study were collected exclusively from areas where otters still persisted; areas where otters had disappeared were later found to have elevated concentrations of industrial pollutants that accumulate in shellfish -- the otters' primary food source.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is a SURVIVORSHIP BIAS question. Larsen tested water quality only where otters still lived and found it normal -- but that's exactly where you'd expect conditions to be fine. The areas where otters vanished had polluted shellfish. Larsen drew his conclusion from an incomplete sample. C is tempting because long-standing orca predation undermines the idea that orcas are a NEW threat, but it doesn't explain the recent decline. B is tempting but a small dietary fraction of mammals could still devastate otters. Shortcut: always ask 'where did they NOT sample?'
END QUESTION

QUESTION 8
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Historian Callum Fraser studied medieval Scottish trading records from the port of Dunmore, dated to approximately 1300 CE. Fraser found that the port's customs ledgers listed large quantities of Flemish woolen cloth arriving by ship. Fraser concluded that Dunmore maintained direct maritime trade with Flanders (modern-day Belgium) during this period.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Fraser's conclusion?
A: Several other Scottish ports during this period also received shipments of Flemish woolen cloth and maintained documented trade relationships with Flemish merchants.
B: Further analysis of the customs ledgers revealed that all shipments of Flemish cloth recorded at Dunmore arrived on English merchant vessels departing from London, and no Flemish vessels were recorded entering Dunmore's harbor during this period.
C: Archaeological evidence suggests that Scottish wool and hides were exported to Flemish cities during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries.
D: Flemish woolen cloth was considered among the finest in medieval Europe and was widely sought after by Scottish, English, and Scandinavian consumers.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Fraser says DIRECT maritime trade with Flanders. B shows the cloth came via LONDON on ENGLISH ships -- Dunmore traded with England, which traded with Flanders. The goods originated in Flanders, but the trade relationship was indirect. The presence of Flemish goods does not prove direct trade with Flanders. Shortcut: when a conclusion claims 'direct' contact or trade, look for evidence of an intermediary.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 9
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Sociologist Amira Hassan studied the relationship between neighborhood green spaces and childhood asthma rates in a large Middle Eastern city. Hassan found that neighborhoods with more trees and parks had 25% lower rates of childhood asthma. Hassan proposed that trees and vegetation reduce asthma by filtering airborne particulate matter, thereby improving local air quality.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Hassan's proposed mechanism?
A: Air quality monitoring stations showed that particulate matter concentrations were significantly lower in neighborhoods with dense tree cover than in neighborhoods without trees, even after accounting for differences in traffic volume, industrial activity, and socioeconomic status between neighborhoods.
B: Children in neighborhoods with more green spaces spent an average of two additional hours per week playing outdoors compared to children in neighborhoods with fewer green spaces.
C: Neighborhoods with more green spaces tended to have higher household incomes and better access to healthcare facilities than neighborhoods with fewer green spaces.
D: Indoor air quality measurements taken inside homes showed no significant difference between neighborhoods with and without green spaces.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Hassan's mechanism is: trees filter particulate matter -> better air quality -> less asthma. A confirms the middle link (particulate matter IS lower near trees) and CONTROLS for confounds (traffic, industry, SES). Without these controls, the correlation could be explained by wealthy neighborhoods having both trees AND less pollution. C actually identifies this exact confound. D is interesting -- similar indoor air suggests the outdoor environment matters -- but it doesn't directly confirm that TREES caused the outdoor difference. Shortcut: mechanism support must show the proposed intermediate step actually occurs.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 10
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Epidemiologist Liam Nakamura conducted a ten-year study of 50,000 adults and found that those who consumed at least three servings of fermented foods (such as yogurt, kimchi, and sauerkraut) per week had a 40% lower rate of clinical depression diagnoses than those who consumed fewer than one serving per week. Nakamura concluded that regular consumption of fermented foods protects against depression by promoting a healthy gut microbiome, which in turn produces neurotransmitter precursors that regulate mood.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Nakamura's conclusion?
A: The specific fermented foods consumed varied widely among participants, with some consuming primarily dairy-based ferments and others consuming primarily vegetable-based ferments with different bacterial profiles.
B: Participants who consumed fermented foods regularly showed measurably different gut microbiome compositions compared to those who consumed fewer fermented foods.
C: Clinical records revealed that patients diagnosed with depression frequently experienced significant appetite changes and dietary simplification as early symptoms of their condition, leading them to eliminate fermented foods from their diets months before receiving a formal diagnosis.
D: Depression has a strong genetic component, with twin studies estimating heritability at approximately 40%, suggesting that biological predisposition plays a significant role alongside environmental factors.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is REVERSE CAUSATION. Nakamura assumes eating fermented foods -> less depression. C suggests the causal arrow goes the other way: developing depression -> eating fewer fermented foods (through appetite changes). The low fermented food intake is a SYMPTOM of pre-clinical depression, not a cause of protection. B is a trap -- it seems to support the gut-brain link, but microbiome differences don't prove they CAUSE mood changes. Shortcut: in observational diet studies, always consider whether the health condition itself changes eating behavior.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 11
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Dance historian Claudia Moreau studied the choreographic works of Haitian-American dancer and choreographer Jean-Louis Beaumont, who was active in New York from 1955 to 1980. Moreau noted that Beaumont's choreography frequently incorporated asymmetric rhythmic patterns and polyrhythmic structures. While some scholars have attributed these patterns to the influence of American jazz dance, Moreau argues that Beaumont drew primarily from traditional Haitian Vodou ceremonial dance, which features similar polyrhythmic elements.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Moreau's argument?
A: Beaumont performed regularly at jazz clubs in Harlem during the late 1950s and early 1960s, where his work was well received by audiences.
B: Audiences and critics in New York frequently described Beaumont's choreography as 'jazz-inflected' in reviews published during the 1960s.
C: Several other Haitian-American choreographers working in New York during the same period explicitly cited jazz dance as a primary influence on their work.
D: Beaumont's personal notebooks contain detailed notations of specific Vodou ceremonial rhythms he observed during visits to Haiti, with arrows linking these rhythms to passages in his choreographic scores that use the same patterns.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Moreau claims Vodou, not jazz, is the primary source. D provides the strongest possible evidence: Beaumont's own notebooks showing he (1) transcribed Vodou rhythms and (2) explicitly mapped them to his choreography. C is a trap -- other Haitian choreographers citing jazz actually undermines Moreau's argument slightly. B shows audiences thought it was jazz, which suggests the distinction is non-obvious. Shortcut: direct documentation of the creator's process always trumps external observations about what the work resembles.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 12
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Educational psychologist Sven Johansson conducted a study in which 500 students at a university were identified as performing in the bottom 10% on their midterm exams. These students were enrolled in a special intensive review course. On the final exam, the group's average score improved by 12 percentile points. Johansson concluded that the intensive review course was highly effective at improving academic performance for struggling students.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Johansson's conclusion?
A: Students who completed the intensive review course reported high satisfaction and said they felt more confident about the material.
B: A control group of bottom-10% students who were not enrolled in any review course also improved by an average of 11 percentile points on the final exam, a pattern consistent with the statistical phenomenon in which extreme scores tend to move toward the average on subsequent measurements.
C: The instructors who taught the intensive review course were adjunct faculty rather than the tenure-track professors who taught the original courses.
D: Students in the intensive review course reported studying an average of 8 additional hours per week compared to their study habits before the midterm.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is REGRESSION TO THE MEAN. When you select people at their worst moment (bottom 10% on one test), they will tend to score closer to their true average on the next test -- even without any intervention. B shows a control group improved by almost the same amount (11 vs 12 points) WITHOUT the course. The course added almost nothing beyond natural statistical rebound. D is tempting because more studying seems to explain the improvement, but it actually supports Johansson (effort -> improvement). Shortcut: when a study selects extreme performers, always suspect regression to the mean.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 13
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Planetary scientist Rosa Gutierrez discovered that a large crater on Mars, designated Crater Helios, contains layered mineral deposits on its floor. Three competing hypotheses have been proposed for the origin of these deposits: (1) they were laid down by a standing body of water that once filled the crater, (2) they were deposited by wind over millions of years, or (3) they are volcanic in origin, produced by lava flows that pooled in the crater. Gutierrez favors the standing-water hypothesis.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Gutierrez's standing-water hypothesis?
A: Crater Helios is one of the deepest impact craters in its region of Mars, with a floor approximately 4 kilometers below the surrounding terrain.
B: Layered mineral deposits have been observed in numerous Martian craters, and scientists have proposed various formation mechanisms for different sites.
C: The mineral layers contain clay minerals that form only in the presence of liquid water, the layers are horizontally uniform in thickness across the crater floor (inconsistent with directional wind deposition), and they lack the crystalline structures characteristic of cooled volcanic rock.
D: High-resolution imagery shows channel-like features on the crater's rim that appear to have been carved by flowing liquid.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: With THREE competing hypotheses, the best support ELIMINATES THE ALTERNATIVES while confirming the favored one. C does triple duty: clay minerals require water (supports water hypothesis), uniform thickness contradicts wind (eliminates hypothesis 2), and no volcanic crystal structure contradicts lava (eliminates hypothesis 3). D only shows water entered the crater, which is necessary but not sufficient -- water could have flowed through without forming a standing lake. Shortcut: when multiple hypotheses compete, the best answer rules out alternatives, not just supports the favored one.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 14
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Historian Miriam Goldstein studied the role of women in the medieval spice trade along the Indian Ocean. Traditional scholarship has assumed that women played no direct role in long-distance maritime commerce during this period. However, Goldstein found references in twelfth-century Arabic merchant correspondence to a female trader named Sitt al-Kull who operated ships between the ports of Aden and Calicut. Goldstein argues that women like Sitt al-Kull were active participants in Indian Ocean commerce, not merely household managers as previously assumed.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Goldstein's argument?
A: Port authority records from Aden, discovered independently of the merchant correspondence, list cargo taxes paid by three women identified as ship owners during the twelfth century, including one entry matching the name Sitt al-Kull.
B: Other medieval Arabic documents describe women inheriting commercial property and managing family finances, indicating women had some economic agency during this period.
C: The port of Calicut was one of the busiest trading centers in the Indian Ocean during the twelfth century, receiving ships from Arabia, Persia, China, and Southeast Asia.
D: Merchant correspondence from the period frequently mentions luxury goods associated with women, such as textiles and perfumes, among the cargoes shipped between Aden and Calicut.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Goldstein has ONE source (merchant letters). A provides INDEPENDENT CORROBORATION from a completely different archive (port records), confirming that women owned ships AND matching a specific name. Independent corroboration is the strongest support for a historical claim. B is tempting but 'managing family finances' actually fits the OLD interpretation (household role). D mentions women's goods but doesn't prove women themselves traded. Shortcut: for historical claims based on a single source, independent corroboration is the gold standard.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 15
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Epidemiologist Grace Kamau analyzed health data from 200 cities across Sub-Saharan Africa and found that cities with higher average fruit and vegetable consumption per capita had lower rates of cardiovascular disease. Kamau concluded that increasing individual fruit and vegetable intake reduces a person's risk of developing cardiovascular disease.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Kamau's conclusion?
A: Self-reported dietary surveys, which were used to estimate fruit and vegetable consumption in the study, are known to overestimate actual intake by an average of 15-20%.
B: Cities with higher fruit and vegetable consumption also tended to have more public recreational facilities and higher rates of regular physical exercise among residents.
C: Genetic factors play a significant role in cardiovascular disease risk, and populations in different African regions have varying genetic predispositions to heart disease.
D: Within individual cities that had high average fruit and vegetable consumption, residents who personally consumed above-average amounts of fruits and vegetables showed no significant difference in cardiovascular disease rates compared to residents in the same cities who consumed below-average amounts.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is the ECOLOGICAL FALLACY. Kamau observed a pattern at the CITY level (cities with more produce consumption have less heart disease) and drew a conclusion about INDIVIDUALS (eating produce reduces personal risk). D shows that within cities, individual consumption doesn't predict individual disease -- the city-level pattern doesn't hold at the person level. Something else about those cities (infrastructure, wealth, healthcare access) may explain both high produce consumption AND low disease rates. Shortcut: when group-level data supports a claim about individuals, check whether the pattern holds within groups.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 16
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Urban planner Daisuke Ito studied the effects of converting a four-lane road into a two-lane road with dedicated bicycle lanes in a mid-sized Japanese city. Some residents and business owners opposed the conversion, predicting that reduced car capacity would increase traffic congestion and harm local businesses. Ito collected data for two years after the conversion and argues that the road diet actually improved both traffic flow and local economic activity.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Ito's argument?
A: Surveys of cyclists using the new bike lanes reported high satisfaction with the lanes' width, surface quality, and separation from vehicle traffic.
B: Average vehicle travel times along the corridor decreased by 8% after the conversion due to fewer lane-change conflicts and left-turn delays, while sales tax revenue from businesses along the road increased by 12% compared to the two-year period before the conversion.
C: Other Japanese cities that implemented similar road diets reported mixed results, with some experiencing traffic improvements and others experiencing increased congestion.
D: Property values along the converted road increased by 5% in the two years following the conversion.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ito makes TWO claims: improved traffic flow AND improved economic activity. B provides before-and-after data confirming BOTH: travel times fell (less congestion) and sales tax revenue rose (more business). D is tempting because rising property values suggest economic benefit, but property values can rise for many unrelated reasons (citywide trends, interest rates). B uses sales tax revenue, which is a more direct measure of local business activity. Shortcut: before-and-after data on the SPECIFIC measures claimed is the strongest support for an impact argument.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 17
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Veterinarian Sarah Obeng noticed that a farm's chickens began producing eggs with stronger shells approximately two weeks after the farmer switched from a conventional feed to a new feed supplemented with ground oyster shells, which are rich in calcium. Obeng concluded that the calcium from the oyster shell supplement was responsible for the improvement in eggshell strength.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Obeng's conclusion?
A: The feed change occurred in early March, and the two-week period before the improvement coincided with a seasonal increase in daylight hours, which is independently known to stimulate calcium metabolism and improve eggshell quality in laying hens.
B: Oyster shell supplements are one of the most commonly used calcium sources in commercial poultry farming worldwide.
C: Laboratory analysis confirmed that the new feed contained 30% more calcium per serving than the conventional feed the farmer had previously used.
D: Not all chickens on the farm showed equal improvement in eggshell strength; younger hens showed more pronounced improvement than older hens.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is POST HOC ERGO PROPTER HOC (after this, therefore because of this). The feed change and shell improvement happened in sequence, but A shows another event happened at the SAME TIME: increasing daylight, which independently improves shell quality. The improvement might be from daylight, not the feed. C is tempting because it seems to support the conclusion (more calcium = stronger shells), but confirming calcium content doesn't prove it caused the improvement when another cause was present. Shortcut: when cause and effect simply follow in time, look for CONCURRENT changes.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 18
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Literary critic Olumide Afolabi compared the early and late short stories of Nigerian author Chimeka Nwosu. Afolabi observed that Nwosu's early stories (1960-1970) average 12 characters per story, while her late stories (1985-1995) average only 4 characters per story. Afolabi concluded that Nwosu intentionally reduced her cast sizes over time as part of a deliberate artistic evolution toward psychological intimacy -- focusing deeply on fewer characters rather than depicting broad social panoramas.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Afolabi's conclusion?
A: Nwosu's late stories received more critical acclaim than her early work, with reviewers frequently praising the depth of character development.
B: Several other Nigerian short story writers of the same generation also produced stories with smaller casts in their later careers.
C: Nwosu attended a prestigious international writers' workshop in 1980, where the curriculum emphasized minimalist narrative techniques.
D: Nwosu's early works classified as 'short stories' by Afolabi were actually published as novellas averaging 80 pages, while her late short stories averaged 15 pages; the reduction in characters is proportional to the reduction in length and consistent with standard character-to-page ratios across all fiction.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is an INCOMPLETE COMPARISON. Afolabi compared character counts without accounting for story LENGTH. D shows the early 'stories' were actually 80-page novellas while the late stories were 15 pages. Fewer characters in shorter works is a structural necessity, not an artistic choice. The comparison was unfair from the start. C is tempting because the minimalist workshop could explain the shift, but it actually SUPPORTS Afolabi's claim that the change was deliberate. Shortcut: when two groups are compared on one measure, check whether they differ on a fundamental dimension that makes the comparison invalid.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 19
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Labor economist Priya Chakrabarti studied the impact of a minimum wage increase in a large Indian state. The state raised its minimum wage by 25% in 2018. Chakrabarti found that employment in the formal sector decreased by 3% in the two years following the increase. However, some economists argued that the employment decline was caused by a simultaneous national economic slowdown, not the minimum wage increase. Chakrabarti maintains that the minimum wage increase was the primary cause of the employment decline.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Chakrabarti's conclusion over the competing explanation?
A: The informal sector in the same state grew by 5% during the same period, as employers shifted workers from formal to informal arrangements.
B: Neighboring states that experienced the same national economic slowdown but did not raise their minimum wages showed no decline in formal sector employment during the same two-year period.
C: The employment decline was concentrated in labor-intensive industries such as textiles and food processing, where labor costs represent a large share of total production costs.
D: A survey of employers in the state found that 60% cited the minimum wage increase as a factor in their hiring decisions during the two-year period.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: The competing explanation is a national economic slowdown. B uses a natural DIFFERENCE-IN-DIFFERENCES approach: neighboring states faced the SAME economic slowdown but DIDN'T raise wages. If those states had no employment decline, the slowdown can't explain the decline in Chakrabarti's state -- the wage increase is the only remaining difference. C seems relevant but is equally consistent with both explanations (labor-intensive industries are sensitive to both wage costs AND economic slowdowns). Shortcut: to isolate cause X from confound Y, find a comparison group exposed to Y but not X.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 20
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Materials scientist Kofi Mensah developed a theoretical model predicting that a specific alloy of titanium and niobium should exhibit superconductivity -- conducting electricity with zero resistance -- at temperatures below -250 degrees C. Mensah's model is based on calculations about electron pairing behavior in the alloy's crystal lattice. Other physicists have expressed skepticism, noting that the model relies on untested assumptions about electron interactions in mixed-metal lattices.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Mensah's model?
A: Other titanium-based alloys have been observed to exhibit superconductivity at temperatures below -260 degrees C, though none contain niobium.
B: A computational simulation using the same theoretical framework as Mensah's model independently reproduced his prediction of superconductivity at -250 degrees C for the titanium-niobium alloy.
C: Laboratory experiments with a synthesized sample of the titanium-niobium alloy at the predicted composition demonstrated zero electrical resistance at -251 degrees C, within 1 degree of Mensah's prediction.
D: Pure niobium is a known superconductor that transitions to superconductivity at -263.9 degrees C, one of the highest transition temperatures among elemental metals.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Mensah made a SPECIFIC PREDICTION (-250 degrees C for a specific alloy). The strongest support for a theoretical model is EXPERIMENTAL CONFIRMATION of its prediction. C shows the alloy became superconducting at -251 degrees C -- within 1 degree of the prediction. B is a deliberate trap: using the SAME theoretical framework to reproduce the result is CIRCULAR -- it only proves the math is consistent, not that the assumptions are correct. Shortcut: models are supported by independent experimental evidence, never by re-running the same model.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 21
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Archaeologist Keiko Taniguchi surveyed 30 ancient settlement sites along the southern coast of Japan, dated to approximately 3000 BCE. Taniguchi found that none of the sites contained obsidian tools, even though obsidian sources existed on nearby islands. Taniguchi concluded that the inhabitants of these settlements had no maritime technology capable of reaching the obsidian-bearing islands, indicating that open-water navigation had not yet developed among coastal populations in this region.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Taniguchi's conclusion?
A: Underwater archaeological surveys near several of the 30 sites uncovered obsidian tool fragments on the seafloor, suggesting that obsidian was used at these settlements but was not preserved in the terrestrial excavation layers due to coastal erosion and rising sea levels since 3000 BCE.
B: Obsidian tools from the same island sources have been found at inland settlement sites approximately 100 kilometers from the coast, dated to the same period.
C: Remains of a dugout canoe dated to approximately 2000 BCE were found at a site 30 kilometers north of Taniguchi's survey area.
D: Small obsidian deposits have been identified on the Japanese mainland, though of lower quality than the island sources.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is an ABSENCE OF EVIDENCE problem. Taniguchi reasons: no obsidian found at coastal sites, therefore no boats to get obsidian. A shows the obsidian WAS there but wasn't preserved due to coastal erosion and sea level rise. The absence in the excavation doesn't reflect the historical reality. B is tempting because inland obsidian use suggests trade networks existed, but it could have arrived overland from mainland sources. C provides evidence of boats, but from 1,000 years later. Shortcut: when a conclusion is based on the ABSENCE of something, check whether that absence has an alternative explanation (poor preservation, wrong search location, etc.).
END QUESTION

QUESTION 22
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: School administrator Fatima Al-Zahra implemented a new 'growth mindset' program at an elementary school, in which teachers praised students for effort rather than ability. After one academic year, students' scores on a standardized test of 'academic resilience' improved by 20%. Al-Zahra concluded that the growth mindset program successfully increased students' actual academic resilience -- their ability to persist through challenging tasks.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Al-Zahra's conclusion?
A: Teachers reported enthusiastic participation in the growth mindset training and said they believed the program was beneficial for students.
B: Students who received the most growth-mindset praise from teachers showed the largest improvements on the standardized test.
C: Research on mindset interventions suggests that behavioral changes may take longer than one academic year to become fully established.
D: The 'academic resilience' test consisted entirely of self-report questions asking students whether they agreed with statements like 'I keep trying when schoolwork is hard,' and students who had been taught about growth mindset were more likely to endorse these statements regardless of whether their actual task persistence -- measured by observed behavior on a difficult puzzle -- had changed.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is a CONSTRUCT VALIDITY problem. Al-Zahra measured 'academic resilience' with a self-report test, but D shows the test measures what students SAY about themselves, not what they DO. Students learned the 'right answers' from the program (say you persist) without actually persisting more. The measurement tool doesn't capture the real construct. B is a trap -- it seems to show the program works, but if the test itself is flawed, higher scores don't mean more resilience. Shortcut: when a study claims to improve X, check whether the measure of X actually captures X.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 23
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Astronomer Lucia Ferreira observed an unusual pattern in the orbital dynamics of a binary star system designated VX-892. The two stars orbit each other with a period of 5.7 years, but Ferreira detected a slight wobble in their shared center of mass that repeats every 2.3 years. Ferreira proposed that the wobble is caused by an unseen third body -- likely a massive planet or brown dwarf -- orbiting the binary system at a greater distance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Ferreira's proposal?
A: Approximately 15% of known binary star systems have been found to harbor third bodies orbiting at wider separations.
B: Infrared imaging of the region surrounding VX-892 revealed a faint heat signature at a position and distance consistent with a brown dwarf in a 2.3-year orbit around the binary system's center of mass.
C: Computational modeling shows that a third body could maintain a stable orbit around the VX-892 binary system at separations greater than 3 astronomical units.
D: The 2.3-year wobble has remained consistent in amplitude and timing over 15 years of observations, ruling out instrumental error as an explanation.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ferreira predicts an unseen companion. B provides INDEPENDENT DETECTION through a different method (infrared imaging) that finds an object at the right position for a 2.3-year orbit. This is the strongest type of support: a prediction confirmed by an independent observation. D is tempting because ruling out instrument error strengthens the observation, but consistent wobble could have other explanations (tidal effects, magnetic cycles). C shows stability is possible but doesn't prove a companion exists. Shortcut: for 'unseen object' hypotheses, direct detection through an independent method is the gold standard.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 24
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Art critic Helena Vasquez examined the auction records of contemporary abstract paintings sold in New York galleries between 2015 and 2025. Vasquez found that paintings using predominantly blue color palettes sold for an average of 35% more than paintings using predominantly red color palettes. Vasquez concluded that the color blue has an inherent aesthetic appeal that increases the perceived artistic value of abstract work, making blue paintings more desirable to collectors.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Vasquez's conclusion?
A: Psychological research has found that the color blue is consistently rated as more calming and pleasant than red across cultures.
B: Blue-palette paintings were produced in significantly larger numbers than red-palette paintings during the study period, suggesting that many artists were drawn to blue.
C: The three highest-selling artists in the dataset -- who accounted for over 40% of total auction revenue -- all happened to work predominantly in blue palettes, and when their sales were removed from the analysis, blue and red paintings sold at statistically equivalent prices.
D: Online auction platforms, which accounted for a growing share of art sales during the period, showed no significant price difference between blue and red paintings.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is BASE RATE / COMPOSITION BIAS. The overall average was skewed by a few ultra-expensive artists who happened to prefer blue. It's not that blue paintings sell for more -- it's that expensive ARTISTS used blue. Remove those artists, and the color effect vanishes. A is a trap: blue being pleasant could support Vasquez. D somewhat weakens (no effect online) but is less direct than C, which identifies the exact statistical flaw. Shortcut: when an average is cited as evidence, check whether a small subset is driving the entire result.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 25
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Public health researcher Omar Diop studied a rural region in Senegal where rates of waterborne illness dropped by 50% between 2018 and 2023. Diop noted that during this period, the regional government installed chlorine-dispensing systems at community water points. Diop concluded that the chlorination program was responsible for the decline in waterborne illness.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Diop's conclusion?
A: No other changes to water infrastructure, sanitation systems, or hygiene education programs were implemented in the region during the 2018-2023 period, and the decline in waterborne illness was concentrated in villages that received chlorine dispensers rather than being evenly distributed across the region.
B: Chlorine is a well-established disinfectant that has been shown to eliminate more than 99% of waterborne bacterial pathogens in controlled laboratory settings.
C: Neighboring regions that did not receive chlorine dispensers also experienced a decline in waterborne illness during the same period, though the decline was smaller.
D: Community surveys showed that over 80% of residents in the region used the chlorine dispensers regularly and reported that they trusted the safety of chlorinated water.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Diop claims chlorination caused the decline. The main threat is that SOMETHING ELSE changed during 2018-2023. A eliminates alternatives by confirming nothing else changed AND shows the decline is geographically concentrated where dispensers were installed. B confirms chlorine CAN kill pathogens (necessary but not sufficient). D shows people used the dispensers (important but doesn't prove health outcomes). Shortcut: for 'intervention X caused outcome Y,' the strongest support eliminates alternative causes while showing Y tracks with X.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 26
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Environmental scientist Ingrid Bakken tested a new biodegradable plastic made from seaweed extract. In laboratory experiments, Bakken demonstrated that the plastic decomposed completely within 90 days when placed in a composting environment maintained at 60 degrees C with controlled moisture and microbial activity. Bakken concluded that the seaweed-based plastic offers a viable solution to ocean plastic pollution because it will decompose rapidly if it enters marine environments.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Bakken's conclusion?
A: The seaweed-based plastic costs approximately four times more to produce per kilogram than conventional petroleum-based plastics.
B: The seaweed-based plastic maintained its structural integrity for over two years under normal storage conditions, suggesting it would not degrade prematurely during regular use.
C: Conventional plastics in the ocean break down into microplastics rather than fully decomposing, and these microplastics persist for hundreds of years.
D: When samples of the seaweed-based plastic were submerged in seawater at typical ocean temperatures of 4-15 degrees C, they showed less than 5% decomposition after one year, because the cold temperatures, high salinity, and absence of composting microorganisms dramatically slowed the breakdown process.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is a LAB-TO-FIELD GENERALIZABILITY problem. Bakken tested decomposition in a composting environment (60 degrees C, controlled moisture, rich microbes) and generalized to the ocean. D shows that actual ocean conditions (cold, salty, few microbes) produce almost no decomposition. The lab result doesn't transfer to the real-world context the conclusion addresses. B is tempting because durability seems contradictory, but the conclusion is about what happens AFTER the plastic is discarded. Shortcut: when lab results are generalized to a real-world setting, check whether the conditions match.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 27
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Ancient historian Dimitrios Alexandris studied a collection of inscriptions found at a temple site on the Greek island of Delos, dated to approximately 300 BCE. Several inscriptions reference a 'great fire' that destroyed part of the temple complex. Traditional scholarship has dated this fire to approximately 310 BCE based on the writing style of the inscriptions. Alexandris, however, argues that the fire occurred closer to 280 BCE, based on his analysis of the grammatical forms used in the inscriptions.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Alexandris's revised dating?
A: The island of Delos experienced several documented fires over the course of its ancient history, with at least three major fires recorded in various sources.
B: The writing style of the inscriptions is consistent with a tradition of formal temple inscriptions that remained relatively unchanged on Delos between 320 and 270 BCE.
C: Dendrochronological analysis of charred wooden beams recovered from the fire debris layer at the temple site determined that the outermost tree rings dated to approximately 285 BCE, indicating the wood was harvested around that time and could not have burned before then.
D: Alexandris's method of dating inscriptions by grammatical evolution has been successfully applied to inscriptions at two other Greek temple sites, producing dates consistent with independently verified chronologies.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Alexandris disputes the date using one method (grammar). The strongest support is INDEPENDENT PHYSICAL EVIDENCE confirming his date through a completely different method. C uses dendrochronology (tree-ring dating) to show the wood couldn't have burned before approximately 285 BCE -- close to Alexandris's 280 BCE date and incompatible with the traditional 310 BCE date. D validates Alexandris's METHOD in general but doesn't confirm THIS specific dating. Shortcut: in dating disputes, independent physical evidence always trumps methodological arguments.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 28
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Evolutionary biologist Nalini Raghavan studied two populations of a lizard species living on adjacent Caribbean islands separated by a 20-kilometer strait. The island populations display different limb proportions: lizards on Island A have significantly longer legs relative to body size than lizards on Island B. Raghavan proposed that these differences are the result of natural selection, with each population adapting to different habitat structures -- Island A's open, rocky terrain favors longer legs for fast running, while Island B's dense forest favors shorter legs for navigating branches and undergrowth.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Raghavan's natural selection hypothesis?
A: Genomic analysis identified specific gene variants associated with longer limb proportions that are present at high frequency in Island A's population but nearly absent in Island B's population, and field experiments showed that lizards with longer legs survived at higher rates on Island A's rocky terrain while lizards with shorter legs survived at higher rates in Island B's forest.
B: Neutral genetic markers (not associated with limb development) also differ between the two island populations, indicating that the populations have been genetically isolated for approximately 10,000 years.
C: When lizards from the two islands were crossed in captivity, their offspring displayed intermediate limb proportions, confirming that the differences have a genetic basis.
D: Detailed habitat surveys confirmed that Island A's terrain is predominantly open and rocky, while Island B's terrain is predominantly dense forest with extensive undergrowth.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Raghavan claims NATURAL SELECTION (not random genetic drift) caused the limb differences. To prove selection, you need TWO things: (1) genetic basis for the trait AND (2) fitness advantage in the respective environments. A provides BOTH: specific genes associated with limb length vary between populations, AND field experiments show each limb type survives better in its respective habitat. C only shows heritability (half the requirement). B shows isolation, which is necessary for drift OR selection -- it doesn't distinguish between them. Shortcut: natural selection requires both a genetic basis AND a demonstrated fitness advantage.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 29
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Management consultant Raj Krishnamurthy introduced a new open-plan office layout at a technology company. After six months, Krishnamurthy surveyed employees and found that reported collaboration increased by 40% compared to surveys conducted under the previous cubicle layout. Krishnamurthy concluded that the open-plan office design fosters greater workplace collaboration.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Krishnamurthy's conclusion?
A: Approximately 30% of employees reported preferring the old cubicle layout, citing noise and lack of privacy as concerns.
B: Employees were aware that Krishnamurthy's consulting firm was monitoring collaboration outcomes and that continued funding for workplace improvements depended on positive results, and electronic communication records showed that actual inter-team messaging and meeting frequency had not changed.
C: The technology industry has widely adopted open-plan offices over the past decade, with over 70% of tech companies using some form of open layout.
D: Managers at the company reported that they believed the new office layout had improved team dynamics and communication.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: This is the HAWTHORNE EFFECT (plus social desirability bias). Employees knew their collaboration was being measured and that results affected future workplace investment. They reported more collaboration on surveys, but ACTUAL behavior (electronic messages, meeting frequency) didn't change. The reported increase was an artifact of being observed, not a real change. A is tempting because dissatisfaction seems to weaken the conclusion, but 70% could still genuinely be collaborating more. Shortcut: when improvement is measured by self-report, check whether objective behavioral measures tell the same story.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 30
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Pharmacologist Mei Chen conducted a clinical trial of a new anti-inflammatory drug for treating rheumatoid arthritis. Chen divided 400 patients into four groups receiving different daily doses: 10mg, 25mg, 50mg, and 100mg. After 12 weeks, Chen found that symptom reduction increased proportionally with dose: the 10mg group showed 15% improvement, the 25mg group showed 30%, the 50mg group showed 55%, and the 100mg group showed 70%. Chen concluded that the drug exhibits a consistent dose-response relationship and recommended the 100mg dose as optimal for clinical use.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Chen's recommendation of the 100mg dose as optimal?
A: A placebo control group that was added to a follow-up study showed a 10% improvement in symptoms over the same 12-week period.
B: Other anti-inflammatory drugs currently approved for rheumatoid arthritis achieve similar symptom reduction at lower doses.
C: A 24-week extension of the study showed that symptom improvement plateaued in all groups after 12 weeks, with no additional benefit from continued treatment at any dose.
D: The 100mg group experienced serious adverse events -- including liver enzyme elevations and severe gastrointestinal bleeding -- at a rate of 22%, compared to 3% in the 50mg group, and 15% of 100mg patients discontinued treatment due to side effects, while only 2% of 50mg patients did so.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Chen recommends 100mg as 'optimal' based on efficacy alone. D shows the 100mg dose has SEVERE SIDE EFFECTS (22% serious adverse events, 15% dropouts) that the 50mg dose mostly avoids (3% and 2%). The 50mg dose achieves 55% improvement with minimal harm; the 100mg adds only 15% more improvement at enormous safety cost. 'Optimal' must consider risk-benefit, not just efficacy. C is tempting because plateauing efficacy questions the point of higher doses, but it says ALL doses plateau -- it doesn't specifically undermine 100mg over 50mg. Shortcut: when 'more is better' is the claim, look for nonlinear costs (side effects, diminishing returns, threshold effects).
END QUESTION